

MGT 449: Topics in Operations & Technology
Supply Chain Finance
Syllabus- Summer 2025
Faculty: Christopher Gopal, PhD

Classroom Days:	Thursdays: 630 pm – 920 pm. August 7, 14, 21, 28, Sept 4, 6:30 – 09:20 pm Final Exam/Deliverable September 6..
Location:	Remote: Zoom platform (details to be provided)
Office:	Online
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Course Description

Supply Chains are among the most important and discussed topics at today's business, board and national policy levels. In our complex and technology-intensive environment, *companies do not compete. Supply chains and industries compete. And countries compete through their supply chains.* This is particularly evident in today's environment of tariffs, trade wars and restrictions. Supply Chain Finance and the Financing of operations are fundamental aspects of a company's successful operations and strategic options.

The supply chain typically controls most of a company's costs and cash. Free Cash Flow from operations, Cash-to-Cash Cycles, financial performance, operating margins and supply assurance are major drivers and indicators of shareholder value and sustainable competitive success. A complex and global supply chain cannot be managed successfully without a firm understanding of this topic. The course takes an End-to-End (E2E) "systems perspective" of today's global supply chain and will address the critical areas of *operational finance* (the issues related to the financials and analysis of a company's operations, cash flow and cost management), and *financing the supply chain & operations* (including traditional and newer methods, financing estimation, fintech, costs, benefits and risks). Every CEO, COO and CFO must understand this aspect of the global supply chain. **This course is a critical component of a business education and career and is directed at managers and students in all the major business functions.**

Learning Objectives

The objective of Supply Chain Finance is to provide insights into

- the impacts that the supply chain has on the financials of a company.
- analyzing and optimizing working capital, cash and operational costs, and
- the traditional and more advanced instruments that are used to help finance the operations of the company.

while explicitly considering End-to-End supply chain transactions, flow and risk management.

The course will provide executives and policy makers, with an integrated business understanding of the operations of a company, the financial levers, the supply chain impacts on the financial statements and shareholder value, and the methods and instruments used in financing the company's supply chain and operations.

Course Notes:

The course will consist of four core learning components, the combination of which will create an effective learning environment for students. They include:

1) Lectures

Instructor-led lectures on various topics as outlined in the Course Calendar section of the syllabus.

2) Case Studies

Case studies will generally be data-driven and include concept discussion and analysis.

3) In-Class Discussion

4) Team Research/Project Assignments

The learning platform for the classes will be Zoom.

Each Class session will have one 15 minute break and one lunch break.

Some of the class sessions will be closed early to give teams the opportunity to structure and work on their assignments.

Required Materials

Presentation decks for each class :

These will be posted before the class session. These decks have been developed specifically for the class, and so form a major and integral part of the content.

You should make it a habit of checking Canvas regularly to look for announcements and any newly posted materials. There will also be two major case studies and a few in-class problems geared towards expanding learning opportunities, and these will span the consumer products and electronics environments. These posted materials and readings should be carefully reviewed before each class.

These materials are not for public use and should not be distributed.

Readings:

“Analyzing Financial Statements”, VJ Narayanan, Suraj Srinivasan, Harvard Business Publishing, 2017.

“It may be cheaper to manufacture at home”, Suzanne de Treville, Lenos Trigeorgis (Pub Date: Sep 30, 2010, Product #: R1010F-PDF-ENG)

“When Good Customers are bad”, Remko Van Hoek, David Evans, (Pub Date: Aug 31, 2005, Product #: F0509B-PDF-ENG)

“The Rise of FinTech in Supply Chains”, Dale Rogers, Rudolf Leuschner, Thomas Y. Choi, (Pub Date: Jun 21, 2016, Product #: H02YUG-PDF-ENG)

“A new tariff paradigm: How businesses can respond”, Grant Thornton, April 14, 2025
Tariffs and Global Supply Chains: Will be provided on Canvas

Case Studies:

Sears: A Struggle for Survival, (Case Study, Anupam Mehta, Sanchit Taneja, Utkarsh Goyal, Ivey Business School Foundation, 2019, Version No. 2019-07-15, Western University, London, Ontario.)

The Fall of Greensill, (Case Study, hbsp.harvard.edu, S. Alex Yang, Lisa Duke, London Business School, LBS 250, September 2021)

TradelX: Blockchain-Enabled Trade Finance in Global Supply Chains, (Erik Hofmann, Maximillian Enthoven and Sara Falleger, Ivey Business School Foundation, W20650, Version 2020-08-11, 2020. cases@ivey.ca: www.iverycases.com)

Supply Chain Finance at Procter & Gamble (Case Study: Benjamin c Esty, E Scott Mayfield, David Lane, Harvard Business School, 9-216-039, May 3 , 2017)

There is no Textbook prescribed for the Course.

However, useful books and material to have as references are:

Financing the Supply Chain:

“Financing the End-to-end Supply Chain: A Reference Guide to Supply Chain Finance” Templar, Hofmann and Findlay. ISBN 978-0749471415
This is available through Amazon.

The overall context: Supply Chain Financing as part of the Global Supply Chain:

“Breakthrough Supply Chains: How Companies And Nations Can Thrive And Prosper In An Uncertain World”, Gopal, Tyndall, Iakovou, Partsch, McGraw-Hill, 2023.

This is available through Amazon

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

Course Grading:

The Grades for this Course will be based on the following:

- One Team Case Study Analysis/Write-up
- A Team Deck Development and Presentation of a Research Assignment
- One Final Case Deliverable/Exam.
- Class Attendance and Participation

Further details will be provided during the class sessions.

SCHEDULE

IMPORTANT ASSIGNMENT DATES AND TIMES

Assignments	Date/Time
Team Case Assignment Submission (Notes G)	August 22nd
Team Case Deck & Presentations (Notes G)	August 28th
Final Exam/Deliverable (Notes I and Notes C, as specified in the class session)	September 6 th

The following describes the guidelines for individual, collaborative or group work:

I – Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.

G – Students work together in groups and turn in one project or assignment for the entire group.

C – Collaboration with classmates is allowed before the Final Exam. However, each student must submit his or her own work.

GRADING

Component	Points [or percentage]
Team Case Assignment Submission	25
Team Research Assignment Deck/Presentations	35
Class Attendance/Participation	10
Final Exam/Deliverable - Individual	30
Total	100

Final grades will be based on your individual and team performance. Two items are considered when assigning final grades:

1. The overall percentage score.
2. Your ranking among all students in the class.

Class Participation and Attendance

It is expected that all students will attend all the classes and participate. One of the class sessions may be pre-recorded, in which case students can review the material and video presentation on Zoom at their convenience. If this is the case, it will be confirmed in the first session.

If, for some reason, you cannot attend a particular class, please let me know in advance.

Participation in Team case discussions, class discussions and team presentations will count

towards Class Participation.

The following are the perspectives that are critical to learning and good class participation:
You should:

- Articulate the issues and point of view clearly.
- Make points and comments that are relevant to the class materials and discussion.
- Ask questions and make comments that are relevant to the global supply chain business environment.
- Display, when discussing case studies or situations, evidence of analysis of the problem.
- Put forward new ideas, when appropriate.

The Critical aspect here is that you participate, regardless of whether you feel the points you are making or the questions you are asking are good.

COURSE CALENDAR

The Course topics and timeframes within this course could be scheduled differently between sessions, and the timing will depend on the class discussion.

	Topics/Activities to be covered on this day	Readings for this day and Homework to be assigned	Deliverables due this day
Week 1 8/7/2025	▪ Course Introduction & Overview ▪ End-to-End Supply Chain Overview and Impacts ▪ End-to-End Supply Chain Costs – System-wide analysis	▪ Reading: “Analyzing Financial Statements”	Start Team Formations
Week 2 8/14/2025	▪ End-to-End Supply Chain Costs – System-wide analysis (contd..) ▪ Operational Finance & Analysis ▪ End-to-End Supply Chain Financing Profile, Inventory and Working Capital ▪ Impacts on Financial Performance	▪ Reading: “When Good Customers are Bad”	Team Formations and Assignments
Week 3 8/21/2025	▪ Impact on Financial Performance (contd...) ▪ External factors impacting costs (e.g., tariffs, trade restrictions) ▪ Cases ▪ Supply Chain Financing – Traditional Methods	▪ Reading: “It May be Cheaper to Manufacture at Home” ▪ Reading: “A new tariff paradigm: How businesses can respond”	
8/22/2025: COB Case Assignment Submission			
Week 4 8/28/2025	▪ Supply Chain Financing – Traditional Methods (Contd) ▪ Supply Chain Finance Newer Methods and Models ▪ Discussion: Assignment ▪ Discussion: TradeIX Case	▪ Reading: “The Rise of FinTech in Supply Chains” ▪ Case Study/Reading: TradeIX: Blockchain-Enabled Trade Finance in Global Supply Chains	
8/28/2025/COB: Team Research/Assignment Deck Submission			
Week 5 9/4/2025	▪ Supply Chain Finance Newer Methods & Models (contd...) ▪ Greensill Case Study Costs, Benefits and Risks	▪ Case Study: The Fall of Greensill	Team Presentations
Final Exam/Deliverable: 9/6/2025:			

Faculty Bio: Christopher Gopal, PhD

Dr. Gopal has over 40 years of experience in global supply chain & operations strategy, execution, and technology in a career that has encompassed industry executive management, consulting and executive education. Dr. Gopal has held executive positions at several leading companies, including Partner & Director of Global Supply Chain & Operations Services at Ernst & Young Consulting, VP in World-Wide Operations at Dell Computer, as well as executive VP positions at Unisys, Overland Storage and SAIC. His consulting clients have included prominent global and regional companies across a range of industries, and he has also assisted in several start-up companies.

Dr. Gopal has served as a Member of the Defense Business Board (DBB) for several years. The DBB provides the Secretary and Deputy Secretary of Defense, as well as other senior leaders, trusted independent and objective advice which reflects an outside private sector perspective on proven and effective best business practices for consideration and potential application to the Department.

Chris is also a Supply Chain Advisor to the Global Fund based in Geneva, a public-private organization designed to accelerate the end of AIDS, tuberculosis, malaria and COVID as epidemics. He has also served on a White House sub-committee on Manufacturing Technologies

Chris currently consults with companies, serves as the Strategic Advisor at several small companies, teaches at the University of California San Diego and at the University of Southern California, where he also serves on the Advisory Board of the Global Supply Chain Management Center

Dr. Gopal has spoken and served as an invited panelist at major industry forums, including the Milken Institute Global Forum, IATA World Conferences, the OMI-OECD Forum, the Harvard Business Review Forum, the USC "Learning from the Pandemic to Improve Healthcare" Symposiums in 2021-22, the Energy Institute, Texas on "Sustainable Supply Chains", the EU Conference on Monopoly and Security held recently in Brussels, the Panel on *"The Next World System: Can US Trade Policy Make Americans More Secure, Democratic, and Prosperous?"* at the National Press Club in Washington, and recently testified before the Congressional US-China Committee on Supply Chain security in Washington.

Dr. Gopal is the co-author of four books on Supply Chain Management. His latest book, *"Breakthrough Supply Chains: How companies and nations can thrive in an Uncertain World"* was published June 2023 and has been endorsed by the Council for Supply Chain Management Professionals and been accepted into the Pentagon Library.

Chris holds a PhD from the University of Southern California, and an MBA from the Cranfield School of Management, UK.